

Khwaja Muhammad Din Khaliqi Dehlavi—and “Rushdie” was a name my father chose to simplify matters, picked because of his admiration for the Andalusian Muslim philosopher Ibn Rushd, “Averroes” to the West, author of the celebrated *Tahafut al-Tahafut*, the “Incoherence of the Incoherence,” his spirited reply to Ghazali’s “Incoherence of the Philosophers”, in which he defended human thought—philosophy—against the hard-line argument advanced by Ghazali that much philosophy, such as the thought of Aristotle and Ibn Sina, was contrary to Islam. My father greatly admired Ibn Rushd’s arguments against Islamic literalism and in favour of interpretation—of openness—which are the brilliant precursors of an argument that continues right up to today.

In other words, I was born into a house of argument and debate, raised in the belief that open disagreement is the best

guarantee of an open society. I have said before, and say again, that freedom of thought is not a tea-party, not a place where people sit about politely and make gentle, inoffensive, tedious chit-chat. True intellectual freedom, from which artistic freedom derives, is a rough and tumble thing, and strongly argued disagreement is its hallmark, not meek agreement or acquiescence. A free society is one which creates an arena for such discourse and then fiercely protects the rights of all disputants to make their case, all disagreements to be voiced, all inspirations and challenges to be expressed, faced, and learned from: perhaps rejected, perhaps not.

My mother’s father, Dr Ataullah Butt, taught me the same lesson from a different end of the religious spectrum. Unlike my father, my maternal grandfather was a devout man, who said his prayers five times a day throughout his life, and made the pilgrimage to Mecca. He was also a man of infinite sweetness, tolerance and patience, who taught his brood of grandchildren that there were to be no limits, in his presence, on what could and could not be discussed. “Babajaan, I’ve decided I don’t believe in God,” a serious little boy could say to him and he would reply, “Is that so? Come and sit down here beside me and explain to me how you arrived at such a foolish conclusion.” His tone might be gruff, but his eyes were twinkling. Openness: it was always openness with Dr Butt. And we learned from that twinkle in his eyes that it was all right to push, and test, and try to open the universe a little more, even before we knew how.

My life has taken me to many countries and many cultures but I have always known and tried to demonstrate in my work that the idea of cultural openness which I am here to commend to you, and which has been of such importance to me always, is an idea given to me in India, by Indians, an idea with old Indian roots, valued in every Indian community. This is no alien idea being foisted on India by outsiders. It is our heritage as Indians, integral to our own culture, and we must preserve it or lose some essential part of ourselves.

As India itself rises to the forefront of the international scene, this parallel rise of Indian culture should be a matter of pride to all Indians. However, my mention of Mr Husain inescapably leads me to some sadder, darker

“THE GREAT ARTIST CAN MAKE THE UNIVERSE FEEL GREATLY ENLARGED. THE LESSER ARTIST MUST SETTLE FOR LESS. THE BAD ARTIST FAILS IN THE ATTEMPT, BUT ALL ART WANTS TO PUSH AGAINST BOUNDARIES.”

SALMAN RUSHDIE

